

Module 08: Planning — Organizing a Crochet-Along

Learning Objectives

1. Apply the concept of expected free energy to planning group projects — how crochet circles evaluate options by weighing predicted difficulty, satisfaction, and learning value.
2. Describe how organizing a crochet-along requires temporal planning — coordinating the circle's collective actions across weeks or months.
3. Synthesize all course concepts by showing how they integrate in planning and executing a group crochet project.

Introduction

"Let us do a crochet-along!" The suggestion lands at the table and something shifts. Suddenly the circle is not just a collection of individuals working on separate projects — it is a group contemplating a shared future. Which pattern? What yarn? How many weeks? What if some people fall behind? The planning process that unfolds is, in Active Inference terms, one of the most sophisticated things a crochet circle does: it is **collective temporal planning under uncertainty**, using expected free energy to evaluate options and coordinate action across time.

This final module brings together everything we have explored — systems, agents, perception, cognition, action, learning, and communication — and shows how they all integrate when a circle plans and executes a group project.

Key Concepts

1. Expected Free Energy and Project Selection

In Active Inference, planning involves evaluating possible future actions by their **expected free energy** — a quantity that balances two components:

- **Epistemic value:** How much will this action reduce my uncertainty? How much will I learn?
- **Pragmatic value:** How well does the predicted outcome align with my preferences? How satisfying will the result be?

When a crochet circle chooses a group project, they are collectively evaluating expected free energy, even if they do not use that language. Consider three options on the table:

Option A: Simple granny square blanket. Low epistemic value (most members already know granny squares), high pragmatic value (everyone can participate, the result is useful and attractive). Expected free energy is low because the outcome is predictable and aligned with preferences, but it offers little new learning.

Option B: Complex Bavarian crochet throw. High epistemic value (most members have never tried this technique, so there is much to learn), moderate pragmatic value (the result would be stunning but requires significant effort). Expected free energy is higher because the outcome is uncertain, but the learning opportunity is rich.

Option C: Amigurumi animal set. Moderate epistemic value (some members know amigurumi, others do not), high pragmatic value (cute, giftable results). The expected free energy depends on the specific composition of the circle.

The group's discussion about which project to choose is, at its core, a negotiation about expected free energy. Different members weight the epistemic and pragmatic components differently — a beginner might prefer high learning value, while an experienced member might prefer a relaxing, predictable project. The group must find the option that minimizes collective expected free energy, balancing challenge with accessibility, novelty with comfort.

2. Temporal Planning: Coordinating Across Time

A crochet-along is not a single action — it unfolds over **weeks or months**. Planning it requires temporal coordination: breaking the project into stages, setting a pace, anticipating obstacles, and building in flexibility.

In Active Inference, temporal planning involves generating a **policy** — a sequence of planned actions that extends into the future. For a crochet-along, the policy might look like:

- **Week 1:** Everyone gathers materials. Share yarn sources, agree on colors, order together if needed.
- **Week 2-3:** Work the foundation and first sections. Experienced members available to help beginners get started.
- **Week 4-6:** Main body of the project. Check in weekly: is everyone on track? Who needs help? Anyone need to adjust the pattern?
- **Week 7-8:** Finishing, blocking, and assembly. Group session for joining, weaving in ends, celebrating.

This policy is not fixed — it is a **predicted trajectory** that will be updated as the project unfolds. If multiple members fall behind, the schedule stretches. If someone discovers a better technique mid-project, the group might adopt it. The policy is a living plan, continuously revised through active inference.

The challenge of temporal planning is **prediction under uncertainty**. The circle cannot know in advance how long each section will take for each member, whether someone will have a life event that interrupts their participation, or whether the pattern will contain a surprise difficulty. Good planning builds in buffers and checkpoints — moments to evaluate how reality is matching the plan and to update the policy accordingly.

3. Skill-Building Progressions

A thoughtful circle can plan not just individual projects but **skill-building progressions** — a sequence of group projects that intentionally develops the circle's collective capabilities over time.

This is planning at a higher level of abstraction. Instead of asking "What should we make next?", the circle asks "What sequence of projects would most effectively expand our collective generative model?"

A progression might look like: 1. **First project:** Simple rectangular blanket in one stitch. Everyone participates successfully. The group builds confidence and coordination. 2. **Second project:** Color-change project (e.g., striped scarf). Introduces color joins and color planning. Members who already know this teach others. 3. **Third project:** Shaped project (hat or garment). Introduces increasing, decreasing, and shaping. Significantly expands the generative model. 4. **Fourth project:** Complex technique (lace, cables, or colorwork). High epistemic value. The circle is now capable of tackling challenges that would have been overwhelming at the start.

Each project in the progression is chosen to sit in the group's zone of proximal development — challenging enough to generate productive prediction error, but achievable with the circle's collective support. The progression itself is a policy — a long-term plan for the circle's learning trajectory.

4. Event Coordination and Community Building

Planning extends beyond projects to **events** — craft fairs, yarn crawls, workshops, charity drives, crochet-in-public-day celebrations. These events require coordination that integrates all the Active Inference concepts we have explored:

- **Systems:** The event creates a temporary extension of the circle's Markov blanket — new people encounter the group, new environments are navigated, new resources are engaged.
- **Agents:** Each member takes on a specific role (organizing, creating inventory, staffing a booth, teaching a workshop), exercising their individual agency within the collective plan.
- **Perception:** During the event, members must read unfamiliar social environments — new audiences, unexpected situations, changing dynamics.
- **Cognition:** The group must think collectively about logistics, problem-solve in real time, and evaluate the event's success.

- **Action:** The event is coordinated collective action — each member's contribution must align with the group's shared prediction of what the event should be.
- **Learning:** The group learns from each event — what worked, what did not, what to do differently next time.
- **Communication:** Planning an event requires extensive communication across all channels — in-person discussion, group chats, written plans, delegated tasks.

The planning process for an event is itself a rich exercise in collective active inference. The group predicts what the event will require, acts to prepare, encounters prediction errors (unexpected costs, logistical challenges, volunteer shortages), and updates the plan. The event itself generates further prediction errors that inform future planning.

Applications

- **The Crochet-Along as Collective Inference Laboratory:** A crochet-along is perhaps the purest expression of everything this course has explored. It requires a system (the circle acting as a coordinated whole), agents (each member with their own model and pace), perception (monitoring each other's progress and emotional state), cognition (collective problem-solving as challenges arise), action (the coordinated act of making), learning (everyone's model expands through the shared experience), communication (constant exchange through both channels), and planning (the temporal coordination that holds it all together). If you want to understand Active Inference in social systems, organize a crochet-along.
- **When Plans Fail Productively:** Not every planned project succeeds. A crochet-along where half the circle drops out, a group project where the pieces do not match, an event that is poorly attended — these "failures" are some of the most valuable learning experiences for a circle. The prediction errors they generate update the group's model of what is feasible, what the members actually want (versus what they said they wanted), and how to plan more realistically in the future. A circle that has weathered a failed plan together has a richer generative model than one that has only experienced success.

Conclusion

Planning is where all the threads of this course come together — literally and figuratively. When a crochet circle organizes a crochet-along, it draws on its identity as a system, the diverse capabilities of its agents, its collective perception and cognition, its capacity for coordinated action, its accumulated learning, and its multi-channel communication. The planning process is collective active inference at its most explicit: predicting a shared future, evaluating options through expected free energy, coordinating a temporal policy, and continuously updating as reality unfolds.

The crochet circle, understood through Active Inference, is far more than a hobby group. It is a living, breathing, stitching community of practice — a system that perceives, thinks, acts, learns, communicates, and plans. It preserves craft knowledge across generations, expands the generative models of all its members, and creates objects and bonds that carry meaning into the world. Every stitch made in a circle is an act of inference, and every circle that endures is evidence that the social systems we build together can be as resilient, adaptive, and beautiful as the fabric we create.